

Shaku Myōen (釈妙円) — Biography Notes

Background research on 自然宗佛國寺's 薬師庵主/住持職 and Rob's actual email contact (bukokuji@gmail.com), ahead of the October 2026 visit. See [\[\[project_shaku_myoen_biography\]\]](#) (memory), [\[\[project_mokurai_genmyo_kagoshima_temple\]\]](#) (outreach history), [\[\[project_bukkokuji_visit_idea\]\]](#) (visit planning), and [mokurai_biography.md](#) (the temple's founder). Compiled from the temple's own site (bukokuji.jimdofree.com biography pages) plus independent library/book catalog records (CiNii, NDL Search, Rakuten Books, Tokyo Metropolitan Library) for her pre-ordination publications. The biographical narrative itself is secondary/self-reported; the book-catalog records are independent corroboration that she was a real published author under her prior name, not proof of the narrative's interpretation.

Identity

- **Birth/pre-ordination name:** 高橋由美子 (**Takahashi Yumiko**). Explicitly **not** the same person as the pop-idol actress/singer of the same name (b. 1974) — this Takahashi Yumiko was already a university-trained health researcher and published author decades earlier; a different, unrelated person.
- **Dharma name:** 妙円 (**Myōen**), received on ordination, 1992-10, Mt. Hiei (比叡山).
- **Current titles:** 薬師庵主 (head of Yakushi-an), 宗教法人自然宗佛國寺 住持職 (head priest, since 2014), 「いのちの学校」校長 (principal, "School of Life").

Timeline

Date	Event
— (age 24)	Fell from ~3,800m to ~3,000m on Mont Blanc, survived with lasting facial/leg/back pain — the pivotal early event of her life. Exact year not given.
—	Traveled China → Taiwan → India → Sri Lanka → Europe → US, seeking treatment for the after-effects and studying medical traditions along the way
1972	Graduated Tokyo University of Science, Faculty of Pharmaceutical Sciences (studied 東洋医学/Eastern medicine alongside pharmacy)
1972	Research assistant, basic biochemistry laboratory, Tokyo Metropolitan Institute of Gerontology (都立老人総合研究所)
1974	Founded 自然堂 — combining a pharmacy, acupuncture clinic, health-food business, and lectures
1980	Founded three companies under 自然美グループ — Kampo (Chinese medicine) pharmacy, beauty salon, dietary consultation, acupuncture, mental-health/counselling, exercise classes, seminars. Ran the group ~12 years, then sold it.

Date	Event
1980s	Became a recognizable public health/wellness figure: her own segment as a TV commentator on TV Tokyo, also appeared on Nippon TV/TBS/Fuji TV/NHK/regional stations; newspaper/magazine serialization; lectures at department stores and cultural centers, Lions/Rotary Clubs, corporate lectures (including Japan Airlines and Nippon Life); lectured both in Japan and abroad (suggests some practical English use at the time, though not proof of current fluency)
1982	Book: 『白髪は体の赤信号』 (<i>Grey Hair Is the Body's Red Signal</i>), 主婦の友社, 214pp
1987	Founded a members-only health/counselling salon for business leaders and influential people
1987	Book: 『21世紀を生きる漢方食健康法』, 誠文堂新光社 (later released as an NDL audio edition, 1990)
1987-08	Book: 『東洋美容科学—21世紀のホリスティックビューティ』, フレグランスジャーナル社 — explicit holistic-health/beauty framing
1988-07	Book: 『突然死を防ぐ—働き盛りのライフスタイル革命』, 駸々堂 — held by multiple university libraries (CiNii)
1988-08	Book: 『健康食にんじん・ごぼう』, 農山漁村文化協会, co-authored with 山口文芳
1987 (after)	Left the health-salon business to live at a water-source area in Aso (「阿蘇の水源地に住むため退職」) — notable because the forest↔water↔life connection central to her later いのちの森 philosophy predates her Buddhist ordination
~1992	Book: 『おいしい水健康法』 (<i>Delicious Water Health Method</i>) — published right before ordination; water as an explicit theme immediately preceding her Buddhist/ecological turn
1992-10	Ordained on Mt. Hiei, received the name 妙円; completed training at 比叡山行院
1992 onward	Entered Zen practice at 自然宗佛國寺
1996	Became head of 薬師庵 in Bōnotsu, Kagoshima (the temple's original/祖院 location)
2014	Became 住持職 (head priest) of 自然宗佛國寺

Also translated 『病気別漢方食養法』 by Chen Huai ren (陳懷仁).

The turning point that led to Buddhism

Per her own account, once her Mont Blanc injuries had improved, she began asking:

人は病院で死ぬことが、自然なのだろうか？

("Is it really natural for people to die in hospitals?")

生まれることも、死ぬことも、ごく自然なことで、病院で取り扱うことではないのでは？

("Aren't birth and death simply natural — not things to be handled by hospitals?")

This led to roughly five years researching longevity communities — **Vilcabamba, Ecuador** and **桐原村 (Yuzurihara), Yamanashi** — including hair-mineral analysis, with findings presented to medical academic societies. Her key finding: interviewees consistently described their happiest moments as *giving* to others, not receiving — which she connects to the Buddhist concept of **利他 (altruism, living for others' benefit)**. This became the philosophical bridge from her health career into Buddhism, and later into **いのちの森** (forest burial as a vehicle for ordinary people to practice 利他 by contributing to forest regeneration).

Relationship to **いのちの森** and Mokurai

She did not originate **いのちの森** independently. The apparent lineage is: **Mokurai (founder; religious corporation registered 1985)** → **自然宗佛國寺** → **Myōen (as 薬師庵主, then 住持職 from 2014)** → **current operational lead of 森林自然葬・いのちの森**. See [mokurai biography.md](http://mokurai.biography.md) and [inochi no mori trademark history.md](http://inochi.no.mori.trademark.history.md) for the trademark's own history — filed 1998, sixteen years before she became 住持職, which argues against her having originated the specific name, though her personal water/forest interest (Aso, 1987) predates even that 1998 filing, so influence in either direction remains plausible and unconfirmed.

Open questions

1. Does **いのちの森** as a name/concept trace back to her own pre-1992 water/health work, or is it purely Mokurai's earlier concept that she came to operate? Timing argues for the latter but isn't conclusive.
2. Exact nature of her pharmacy specialization, and what she actually did at **都立老人総合研究所** — not detailed anywhere beyond "basic biochemistry research assistant."
3. Whether she currently speaks English — her own reply to Rob said only greeting-level (see [\[\[project-mokurai-genmyo-kagoshima-temple\]\]](http://project-mokurai-genmyo-kagoshima-temple)), but her stated 1980s international lecturing makes it at least plausible she had more fluency at some point. Not necessarily a contradiction — career-specific language fluency fades without use.
4. Exact date of the Mont Blanc accident — only "age 24" is given, no year.

Why this matters for the visit

She has an unusually rich pre-Buddhist career — published health author, TV commentator, ran multiple companies — rather than being simply "the person who writes emails for Mokurai." Her own biography is arguably as interesting as his, and gives good rapport material: her Aso water-source period and the **いのちの森** philosophy share an obvious throughline worth asking about directly at the first meeting.

Sources

- Temple's own site: bukokuji.jimdofree.com — 薬師庵主: 釈妙円 and 住職: 釈妙円 biography pages
- CiNii Research (library catalog): 『突然死を防ぐ』, 『東洋美容科学』
- NDL Search (National Diet Library): 『21世紀を生きる漢方食健康法』 (incl. 1990 audio edition)
- Rakuten Books catalog listings: 『白髪は体の赤信号』, 『21世紀を生きる漢方食健康法』
- Tokyo Metropolitan Library catalog: 『健康食にんじん・ごぼう』
- Kosho.or.jp (used-book network): 『おいしい水健康法』